

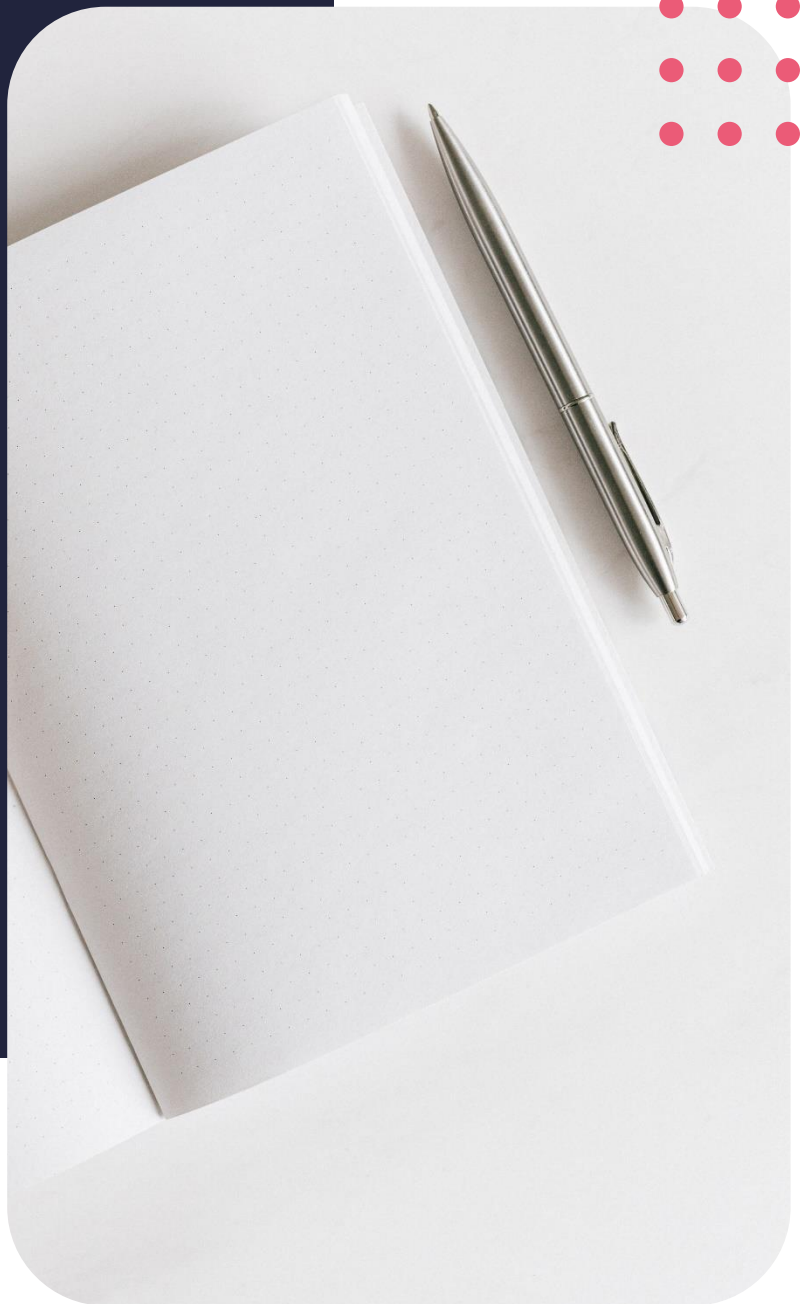
Diploma in Project
Management

Execution & Leadership



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Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Documents produced through execution phase
- Key performance areas
- Soft vs hard skills
- Directive vs supportive leadership

Introduction

Today we are going to be talking about project execution as well as project leadership. The objectives for today's lesson are taught to talk about the different tasks involved in Project Execution's. And we'll also be talking about project leadership and hard versus soft skills as well, as well as direct and supportive leadership styles, and this will give you quite nice opportunity to evaluate yourself and to see what kind of leader you are, as well as identify your different soft and hard skills as well.

Fun fact

Did you know that soft skills are increasing in importance for project managers? Now, 51 per cent of respondents in a PMOS 2013 survey said that soft skills are more important today, while only 19 per cent said that the skill requirement is unchanged. Now, what this means is that your skills that you've learnt through interacting with people in your life, like public speaking skills that are or even empathy, these are skills that you learn through life, whereas your hard skills are things like diplomas and certifications.

Project execution

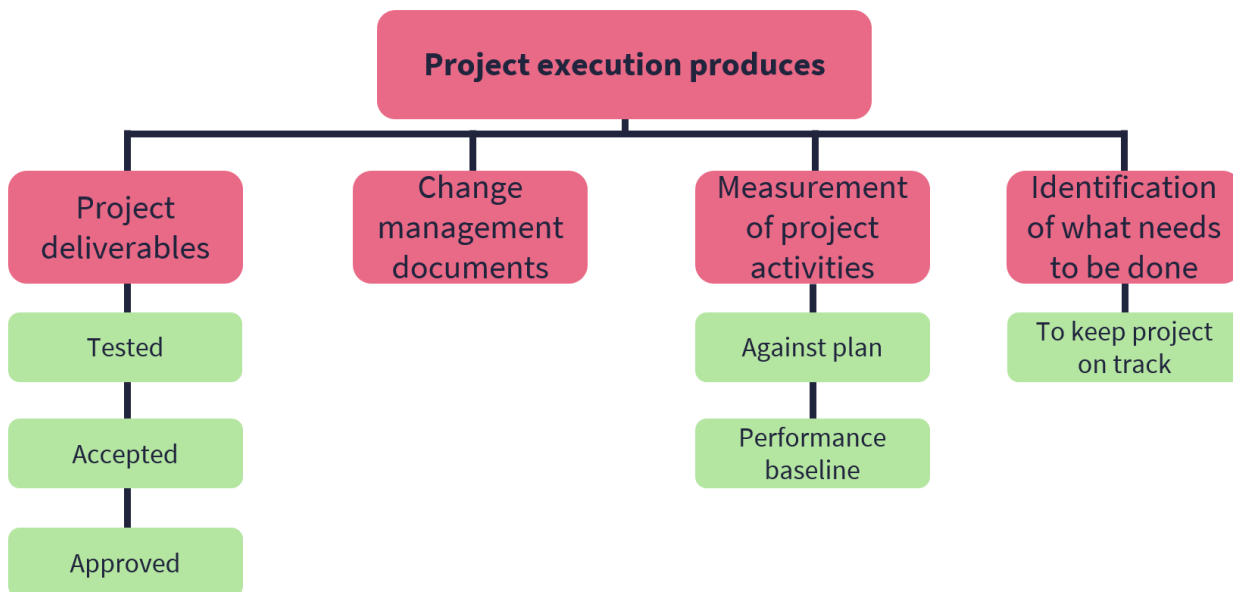
What is project execution? It is the execution phase handles everything that you physically need to do. So everything that you've planned within the planning phase now becomes a reality and you actually start to do the work that you've outlined.

But let's walk through a few of these key areas. First, you will acquire and develop and manage your team. And with this team you will execute your project scope and you can recommend changes and fixes within the project, as you going through. You might identify a few things that need to be changed or improved. You'll need to be in charge of communicating with all your stakeholders. And with this you can then refer to your stakeholder register and also your interest versus influence matrix. You will implement approved changes once you've gone through the change control process that we discussed in lesson five.

You can give recognition and reward to team members in order to keep them motivated. Remember that a happy team is a well performing team. You can also hold status reviews where you inform your team as well as your stakeholders on the progress of your project. And then you just remember to constantly be managing and reviewing your ongoing costs as well as your project scope, because you never want to be in a position where you go over budget or when you indulge in scope creep.

What does the execution phase produce?

What do you produce during the project execution phase? Well, let's break it down into four main areas. We've got project deliverables, our change management documents, measurements of project activities and identification of what needs to be done. Now under project deliverables, we will have to make sure that they've been tested and that the client has accepted them. And lastly, once they've been accepted, have they been approved all around? And do they meet all of the specifications that have been laid out? Then within our measurement of project activities, you will have to measure your estimates versus what actually happened. So you'll have to compare that to your planning phase. Did you plan effectively? And also did you perform against the baseline? So when you decided how long your project was going to take and what your budget needed to be, how accurate were you in these decisions and how can you improve later and under identification? If we needs to be done, you need to keep the project on track. So you need to ensure that you're keeping up with all of the deadlines, milestones and deliverables that you have agreed to in the planning phase.



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Six primary gaps that prevent successful project execution

These are some key things that you need to watch out when you're executing a project to make sure that everything goes smoothly.

First big warning sign is the absence of common understanding. What this means is, does everyone in your team understand what you are trying to achieve in this project? Have you ever tried to work with someone? And at the end of the day, the two of you have a conversation and you realise that you were both going in completely different directions and you've actually just wasted each other's time. That is why it is so important to make sure that every single person in your team understands exactly where you are trying to go with your project. It's a warning sign no one is in absence of common understanding.

Another big warning sign is when you've got disengaged executive sponsors, meaning when there's no they're not showing any interest in your project and they're not giving you any real direction in terms of finances. So they've just left you alone to do what you need to do, essentially. And this is this is bad because you're relying on them and their expertise to help you throughout the project in terms of your funding and direction as well. Huge problems can also be caused by misalignment with your strategic goals, and that links up nicely with the common understanding within your project.

Now, misalignment within your strategic goals can occur when you started executing the project. And you always get carried away with what's going on and you forget what you'd actually outlined during the planning and initiation phase of

your project. See, instead of going on your own little tangent and you lose sight of exactly what it is that you're supposed to be accomplishing.

There's also poor change management. Now, remember what we said within our change management process, this is often where scope creep can come in if you allow every little change to be made. So we need to make sure that we are monitoring the change management process very, very carefully, because you need to weed out the nice to haves versus the necessity items. And remember, you also don't want to be approaching your change control board every day with new changes. It's also going to get very frustrating for the customer as well. So make sure that you have a very carefully planned change management process.

There's ineffective corporate governance, meaning that no one's really guiding you and telling you what to do. Governance being like your government. So they are supposed to be telling you what to do and how to do it.

Project leadership

Now, getting all of this done seems to be quite an impossible task, but I thought what could be quite valuable for all of you is just to talk a bit about project leadership and how you can manage your team in the most efficient way.

Soft skills

A key concept is soft skills, and these skills are not specific to any job and most cannot be learnt. And they apply mainly to your ability to communicate and personal traits that you've developed through your life. Luckily, these skills can be learnt even if they don't come naturally to you. With a little bit of hard work, you can master skills you need. In other words, you can learn how to speak publicly better, or you can learn how to manage your time more efficiently if you're willing to put the work in practice makes perfect.

Some examples of a soft skills will include critical thinking, creative thinking. Now these two are very opposite ends of thinking. So your critical thinking would be over analysing things versus your creative thinking where they are, you know, out of the box thinking is happening there. So you can learn vice versa, whichever one you think you might be lacking. And then his work ethic and this is always wanted to do the best job that you can. Then there's conflict resolution. So how well do you handle yourself in situations of conflict? Do you find yourself trying to avoid conflict altogether? Do you find yourself getting hot headed? How do you handle conflict situations? And then also an ability to collaborate, in other words, to work with others? These are all key skills. And a few of you are thinking, you know, I'm also very bad at conflict resolution. Well, if you go into a bit of research, you can figure out ways to build the skills.

Hard skills

Now, on the opposite end, we have hard skills and these are taught and quantifiable, whether it be a certificate, a professional diploma degree or a master's degree, all of it will be quantifiable, in other words, measurable. And these skills will directly linked to your career path. Let's break this down to a few examples of how schools could be your diplomas and degrees. They could be a marketing qualification, your project management qualification. When you finish this course, you could be multilingual, meaning you can speak many different languages, you could speak computer languages, or you might be great at accounting. So these are skills. You go to school or online institutions and build these skills.

So these are things that can be taught, there can be measured and they can be defined. How this is measured is because you can measure someone's knowledge with an accounting by giving them practical things to do or even giving them theory tests. So these are skills that can be proven.

What do you consider to be your strongest hard skill? I know it's often quite difficult to evaluate yourself like this. But. It's good to know your strengths. So what do you consider to be your strongest hard skill? Based on your hard versus soft skills out of the two that you've chosen, which one do you think is the most important?

Directive leadership

I mentioned earlier that there were two different styles of leadership we'd be discussing today, and those include directive and supportive leadership. But let's start off with DirecTV leadership. DirecTV leaders use a task orientated approach. In other words, they break everything down into different tasks and assign them to different team members. Your DirecTV leaders will select to show control over their subordinates. In other words, they make it very clear the hierarchy within the company or within your project and demonstrate that they have more control over situations than you do. They also dominate interactions. If you're in a meeting, your project manager, your direct leader will make sure that it is clearly understood that they are running that meeting and that they are in charge and then they will also personally manage the completion of tasks. In other words, they will sign off on work that you've done. If they've asked you to build the homepage of websites, they will then go and evaluate that first before it is marked as complete.

Your directive leaders will also supervise you in a very close manner. In other words, probably check in every day or every few hours to make sure that you are performing at maximum capacity. There will also pressure the employees to complete tasks accurately and efficiently. They'll always be there to try and help you improve on processes that you're using so that you can get as much work done as well as possible and then also focus on time management. So making sure that you are using your time as efficiently and effectively as possible.

Supportive leadership

Now, on the other hand, we have supportive leaders and these leaders are going to meet the employees needs and preferences, so they're going to chat to the team and find out what works and what doesn't work. They're going to show concerns for the employee welfare individual group needs and any conflict within the group. So they're going to get involved directly with their team and try and improve situations, as it says here, with conflict within a group.

They want everyone to be in a happy working environment. They're going to encourage a supportive work environment, meaning that employees will be encouraged to help one another and learn from one another, as well as learn from their project manager or their project leader. There will lead with positive feedback in order to make the employee know that they've achieved something. And also to avoid any negative feelings towards the feedback process as a whole.

They will also foster team cohesion and openness, meaning they want the team to get along because they understand that a happy team works better together. They'll also invite employees to be a part of the decision making process. Instead of making decisions outright themselves, they will lean on the employees to help and gather their opinions as well as resources. Overall, your supportive leader is going to just promote a positive morale within your team. And lastly, they're going to facilitate discussions rather than dominate them. And the value in this is they can then lead the discussion and often uncover ideas or possibilities in the group that would have otherwise gone unnoticed. There's nothing worse than when your team member has a brilliant idea, but they're too afraid to share it. So that is somewhere where supportive leader comes in very handy just for interest sake.

What kind of leader do you think all of you are? What qualities are you looking for when you think of a leader? What do you think defines a good, strong leader? Must they be charismatic, must they be empathetic, but don't listen to my suggestions, think for yourselves, what do you think is a key characteristic that you need in a leader? For me, what I like in a leader is someone who's very organised by nature and that that's the project manager and me, I like very organised people with structure.

Conclusion

What I'd like you to do for this lesson's challenge is identify your top three softer skills and also your top three hard skills. And then I'd like you to without telling them what you've said, go and ask a friend or a family member to do the same and then compare the results. The idea here being you thinking what you think your top skills are and then seeing what someone who comes into close contact with you quite frequently, what they've identified as your top skills. And then you can see how you are perceived by others as well.
